

What is left before you go live

The Paystack account, then the platform itself. Prepared 28 July 2026.

You have a clickable prototype. Everything in it is drawn from data held in the browser, so refreshing the page resets it. Going live means two separate jobs that people often confuse: getting the **Paystack account** approved to take real money, and building the **backend** that makes the prototype a real product. The first takes days and costs nothing. The second is the actual work.

Read this first. The Paystack account can be approved in under a week, but it is useless without a backend to call it. Start the Paystack verification today because it waits on other people, and build the backend in parallel.

PART ONE

Getting the Paystack account live

Paystack accounts start in test mode. Test mode works fully — you can build and test the entire billing flow before anyone verifies anything. What verification unlocks is live keys, which move real money into a real settlement account.

What Paystack needs from you

What	Who / how long
[] Register the business. Paystack will verify a real business, so you need a CAC registration (business name or limited company) in the name you want on receipts.	You · already done or 1–3 weeks with CAC
[] Get a TIN from FIRS if the business does not have one.	You · a few days
[] Director's ID and BVN. Valid government ID (NIN, passport or driver's licence) plus BVN for the account signatory.	You · same day
[] A business bank account in the registered name. Settlements land here — a personal account will slow or block approval.	You · 1–3 days at the bank
[] Submit for verification in the Paystack dashboard under Settings → Compliance, and answer any follow-up questions promptly.	You · 1–5 business days for review

What you do once approved

What	Who / how long
[] Decide the billing shape. Paystack has no "every 30 days" interval — monthly bills the same date each month. Either accept that, or run your own 30-day cron. Full explanation in the Paystack setup guide.	You · one decision
[] Create the plan on live mode. Plan codes do not carry over from test — the plan must be created again with live keys. Amount is in kobo: 650000, not 6500.	Developer · minutes
[] Swap the environment keys to <code>sk_live</code> / <code>pk_live</code> . The secret key never appears in frontend code.	Developer · minutes
[] Set the live webhook URL. It is configured separately from test, and must be a public HTTPS address — localhost receives nothing.	Developer · minutes
[] Take one real payment on your own card and confirm it settles to the bank account. Refund it afterwards.	You · same day

The single most common mistake. Amounts are in kobo. A plan created at 6500 charges each office sixty-five naira. Check it twice, then check the live plan again after you recreate it.

PART TWO

What is left before the platform is live

The prototype is the front end and the product decisions — every screen, rule and state is settled. What does not exist yet is anything that remembers, verifies or charges. Here is the honest list, roughly in build order.

1 · The backend and database

Nothing survives a refresh today. You need a server and a database holding centers, offices, distributors, weekly reports, attendance events, scans, and billing records — plus the API the front end calls instead of reading from `js/data.js`. This is the largest single piece and everything else depends on it.

2 · Real authentication

Sign-in currently accepts any password. Live, you need hashed passwords, real sessions, a working forgot-password email with expiring tokens, and the sign-up codes checked server-side. Also worth deciding before launch: office accounts are shared logins, so pick whether the center leader can force a reset and who is told when a password changes.

3 · QR codes that actually work

The codes in the prototype are drawn patterns, not scannable. Live, each event needs a real QR encoding a URL with a signed token, so that scanning it on a phone opens the scan-in page for that event only. Two rules from your spec have to be enforced on the server, not the browser: one device records one person per event, and a code dies when the event closes.

4 · Device identification

The prototype invents a device ID. Live, you set a first-party identifier on the phone the first time it scans and keep a fingerprint as backup for when someone clears it. Worth adding at the same time: a way for the office manager to mark someone present by hand, logged as such, for the dead-battery cases. If there is no honest path, people invent a dishonest one.

5 • Billing wired to Paystack

The card modal is a stand-in. Live, it opens Paystack, and everything that matters happens in the webhook: renewals, failures, expiring cards. You also need the daily job that watches trials ending, the retry-and-suspend policy, and the read-only state for an office that has not paid.

6 • Email

Nothing sends today. At minimum: password resets, "your trial ends in 3 days", failed-payment notices, and the Tuesday reminder to file the weekly report. That last one is what makes the Wednesday evaluation actually work.

7 • Hosting, domain and backups

A domain, HTTPS, a hosted database with automated backups you have actually restored once, and error logging so you know when something breaks before an office tells you.

Rough shape of the work

Piece	Depends on	Rough effort
Backend + database + API	Nothing — start here	3–5 weeks
Authentication and sign-up codes	Backend	1 week
QR codes, tokens, device rules	Backend	1–2 weeks
Paystack billing + webhooks	Backend, verified account	1–2 weeks
Email notifications	Backend	3–5 days
Hosting, domain, backups, logging	Backend	3–5 days
Testing with one real center	All of the above	2 weeks

That is roughly two to three months for one competent full-stack developer, assuming the prototype is the spec and the design does not move. Two developers do not halve it.

PART THREE

Decisions only you can make

These are not build tasks. They are answers the developer will need, and guessing them wastes weeks.

Billing shape. Monthly on a fixed date, or a true 30-day cycle with your own cron? The difference is about one hundred naira per office per year and a meaningful amount of code.

What happens when an office does not pay. The prototype suggests read-only after retries fail, with nothing deleted. Confirm that is what you want, and how many retries.

Who counts in the ranking. Offices are currently ranked by order amount alone. If attendance or report punctuality should matter, decide the weighting before it is built, not after offices have seen the first league table.

Whether the trial needs a card up front. No card means more signups and more freeloaders. Card up front means fewer signups and near-perfect conversion. At £6,500 I would take no card, which is what the prototype does.

Who is allowed to see what. Center leaders currently see device IDs but not IP addresses. Decide whether center leaders should see other centers at all — right now Platform Admins see everything and offices see only their own center.

One suggestion. Run the first month with a single center — Lagere, four offices — on the free trial before anyone is charged. You will find the things no checklist catches: what happens when the hall has no network, whether people actually find their name, whether Tuesday is really when reports get filed.